court. Finally, it remarked that Tata Sons may ‘concede’ that ‘one important decision that the Board [of Tata Sons] took on 16.03.2012 [the appointment of Cyrus Mistry] certainly turned out to be a wrong decision of a lifetime’.

Importantly, the court upheld what Ratan had maintained throughout, that ‘there never was a case to begin with. That the original cause of action was Mistry’s dismissal as chairman of Tata Sons. Everything else was a dressing up of that cause.’ The court also didn’t mince any words when it said: ‘Though the complainant companies padded up their actual grievance with various historical facts to make a deceptive appearance, the *causa proxima* for the complaint was the removal of CPM from the office of Executive Chairman.’ It even expressed astonishment on how a person who was chosen to succeed Ratan could accuse him of prejudice towards minority shareholders. ‘It is an irony that the very same person who represents shareholders owning just 18.37% of the total paid up share capital and yet identified as the successor to the empire, has chosen to accuse the very same Board, of conduct, oppressive and unfairly prejudicial to the interests of the minorities’, it said.

The court also observed that Mistry was only removed as director, Tata Sons, after he had filed the petition before NCLT against the Tata Group: ‘CPM himself invited trouble by declaring an all-out war, which led to his removal from [the] directorship.’

On the day of the judgment, 26 March 2021, I was with Ratan at his house. Shantanu Naidu, the general manager of his office, was the only other person there. The verdict was to be livestreamed because of the Covid-19 pandemic.

Ratan was tense. A few minutes past 11 a.m., the scheduled time for pronouncing the judgment, as S.A. Bobde began reading it out, Ratan squeezed his eyes and began biting his lower lip, a rare habit when he is faced with the unknown and is worried. But as he heard the presiding judge, his eyes started sparkling with relief and joy.

After the last sentence was uttered, Ratan rose from his chair, and we went to the anteroom that also serves as his small office. He said nothing at all, though the glow on his face spoke a thousand words. We spoke for a while as his mobile phone refused to stop ringing.

The first call came from Harish Salve, his primary counsel for the case. And the first to visit him after the judgment was Chandrasekaran, who had played a quiet but significant role in crafting the legal strategy.